University of Florida
College of Public Health and Health Professions
PHC 6149 – Public Health Leadership (1 credit)
Spring 2026
Class Meeting Information: Online Asynchronous

Instructor: **Julia R. Varnes, PhD, MPH, MCHES**
Office: HPNP 4177
Office Hours: Wednesdays, 10:30am-11:30am; Other by appt.
Virtual Office: https://ufl.zoom.us/j/94979907070
Use this Zoom link when visiting my virtual office hours, or for any appointments we make.
Phone: 352-294-5382
Email: jrvarnes@ufl.edu
Preferred Course Communication: GroupMe for course questions; Email for personal questions
GroupMe: UFMPH-6149-Spring26
Note: Using the GroupMe for course questions ensures the quickest response from me and also ensures that your peers benefit from the question and answer.

Teaching assistant: Heather Mendez, MPH, CPH, heather.mendez@phhp.ufl.edu

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Pre-requisites: Permission of the MPH Program

Purpose & Outcomes

Course Overview
This graduate course focuses on leadership and management within the Public Health field. Students acquire knowledge of management and leadership skills to grow as a public health professional, build collaborative professional relationships, develop strategies and lead public health efforts as a team member and future leader.

Relation to Program Outcomes
This course is associated with the following MPH core competencies as outlined by the Council on Education for Public Health (CEPH) Core:

- CEPH D2-2.10. Explain basic principles and tools of budget and resource management.
- CEPH D2-2.16. Apply leadership and/or management principles to address a relevant health issue.
- CEPH D2-2.17. Apply negotiation and mediation skills to address organizational or community challenges.

Course Objectives

1. Explain how various leadership styles/approaches influence problem solving, decision making, and system functioning in public health.
2. Identify personal professional growth needs.
3. Identify resource management strategies appropriate for specified public health or health care scenarios.
4. Demonstrate use of ethical principles in public health decision making.
5. Demonstrate professionalism in communication and conduct.
6. Apply leadership principles to address a public health issue.
7. Apply basic negotiation and conflict management skills when addressing an organization or community health challenge.

Instructional Methods & Expectations

This course is run completely online using a mixture of lecture videos, readings, and other materials. You are expected to actively engage in the course throughout the semester. Prior to completing module assignments and discussions, you are expected to fully prepare for participation by completing all module preparatory work. This preparation gives you the knowledge or practice needed to engage in higher levels of learning during the live class sessions. If you do not complete the assigned preparatory work, you may struggle to keep pace with (or meet expectations of) the activities in this course, and it is unlikely that you will reach the higher learning goals of the course. Your thoughtful participation and engagement fosters a rich course experience for you and your peers that facilitates overall mastery of the course objectives.

DESCRIPTION OF COURSE CONTENT

Please see the last page of this syllabus for the **topical course schedule** and **content outline**.

Course Materials & Technology

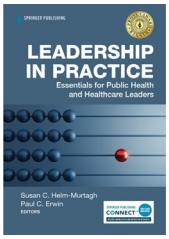
This asynchronous course will use the Canvas LMS. If you experience technical difficulties, please contact the UF Help Desk (learning-support@ufl.edu; 352-392-HELP – select option 2).

UF Internet (eduroam) is available at thousands of locations worldwide!

UF students can access eduroam (highspeed WiFi) for free with their GatorLink log-in credentials. The eduroam network is fast and secure and has more than 10,000 wi-fi hotspots in 106 countries and territories worldwide. Many of these locations are in open spaces and/or large communal rooms, so you can get online while physically distancing and following CDC guidelines in an air-conditioned space. Access is available in rural areas, too! Here's a link to all the eduroam sites.

Required Textbook

- SC Helm-Murtagh & PC Erwin (Eds.). (2023). *Leadership in practice: Essentials for public health and healthcare leadership.* Springer Publishing.



Recommended (Optional) Book

- Morgan, J. (2020.) *The future leader: 9 skills and mindsets to succeed in the next decade.* John Wiley & Sons, Inc.

Additional module readings in the form of book chapters and peer-reviewed articles are listed in the content outline on the last page of this syllabus and are made available to you through Canvas.

Additional Academic Resources

- Career Connections Center: Reitz Union Suite 1300, 352-392-1601. Career assistance and counseling services.
- Library Support: Various ways to receive assistance with respect to using the libraries or finding resources.
- Teaching Center: Broward Hall, 352-392-2010 or to make an appointment 352-392-6420. General study skills and tutoring.
- Writing Studio: 2215 Turlington Hall, 352-846-1138. Help brainstorming, formatting, and writing papers.
- Student Complaints On-Campus: Visit the Student Honor Code and Student Conduct Code webpage for more information.
- On-Line Students Complaints: View the Distance Learning Student Complaint Process
- Enrollment Management Complaints (Registrar, Financial Aid, Admissions): View the Student Complaint Procedure webpage for more information.

Academic Requirements & Grading

Description of Course Assignments

1. Syllabus Quiz (0 pt): You must complete and pass (1/1) the syllabus quiz prior to accessing the remaining content. The syllabus quiz does not count toward your grade.
2. Peer Introductions (5 pts): Associated with Module 1. The purpose of this activity is to provide space for you to introduce yourself to your peers (And learn about them!). On this discussion board, you will also share your prior or current management/leadership experiences.
3. Group organizing discussion (1 pt): This assignment allows you to communicate with your class members on your schedule and availability for completing the Community Negotiation Role Play activity. This discussion board will allow you to select (or otherwise identify) group members who are available to complete the assignment on a schedule that aligns with your own. It is imperative that you complete this assignment so you are assigned to an appropriate group. Check Canvas for details.
4. Advocacy to Build Infrastructure Elevator Speech & Response (15 points): Students will create a 45- to 60-second video using evidence to advocate for or against public health or healthcare infrastructure changes that could result in health and/or quality of life improvements in a specified community (as selected with consideration to the CDC Public Health Infrastructure Center). Students will also post a video or written response to at least one peer.

5. **Case Study (Group Work) Community Negotiation Case Study & Role Play (15 pts):** For this role play activity, students will practice learned negotiation techniques to address a major community health problem. Roles (in the form or title and affiliation) will be assigned by the instructor. Each student should research their role prior to participating in the activity. This is a small group activity that WILL require you to coordinate and participate virtually with a small group. This **Live Virtual Role Play** requires your assigned group **to s**chedule a time to meet virtually and record your 'live' role play interaction. You will need to 1) review the assignment instructions ahead of time; 2) schedule a time to meet; 3) meet at your scheduled time; 4) hit record and play your part! After the role play, you will continue recording while you reflect on the negotiation strategies used during your interaction. One person from each group will upload the recording to the Canvas assignment.
6. **The Leadership Toolkit Discussion Board (18 pts):** Throughout this course, you will begin development of your own *Leadership Toolkit.* This assignment is designed to allow you to share your identified resources with your peers, and identify additional resources for your own toolkit. You are required to contribute a minimum of three times (before three separate deadlines); each post is valued at 5 points each.
7. **Knowledge Quizzes (35 pts):** There are five knowledge quizzes in this course, designed to test your knowledge for each module. Quizzes include questions that cover all content presented in the modules (i.e., readings, lectures/videos, and supplemental materials). While the quizzes are not formally proctored and thus can be considered open book, they are timed and require use of HonorLock. You will not be able to look up every concept covered on the quiz. Therefore, you should complete your readings and review of the lecture/video content from each module before taking the quiz. The quiz will offer feedback based on your answers and you will have two opportunities to take each quiz. However, questions are randomly selected from a pool of potential items, so it is unlikely that you will get the exact same questions twice. Each quiz is worth 5 points for a total of 30 points. For students who miss a quiz, or otherwise require a make-up quiz, there will be a Cumulative Make-Up Quiz at the end of the semester that can be used to replace your lowest quiz grade.
8. **ProSeries (6 pts):** Two of your required MPH Professional Series (ProSeries) sessions are required as part of this course (3 pts each). You must have attended the live session or completed the alternative assignment to receive credit. If you have not yet completed all sessions, to receive full credit you must complete it by the deadlines listed below.
    - Writing Systematic Reviews
    - Disability and Health

Overview of Assignments & Deadlines

ASSIGNMENTS	Points	DEADLINE
Course Content Based Assignments		
1. Syllabus Quiz	0	Jan 16
2. M1 Peer Introductions	5	Jan 23
3. Group Organizing Discussion	1	Feb 13
4. M3 Reflecting on Leadership	5	Feb 20
5. Elevator Speech & Response	15	Mar 11
6. Community Negotiation Case Study	15	Apr 15
7. Leadership Toolkit Resources (three posts at 6 pts ea.)	18	Mar 4, Apr 1, Apr 22
8. Knowledge Quizzes (5 quizzes at 7pts each)	35	Multiple deadlines
9. ProSeries (two at 3 points each)	6	Jan 30, Apr 15
Total	100	

Grading Scale

Percent Earned	93-100	90-92	87-89	83-86	80-82	77-79	73-76	70-72	67-69	63-66	60-62	Below 60
Letter Grade	A	A-	B+	B	B-	C+	C	C-	D+	D	D-	E
Grade Points	4.0	3.67	3.33	3.0	2.67	2.33	2.0	1.67	1.33	1.0	.67	0

Please be aware grades of C- (or below) is not acceptable for graduate students. Graduate students' GPA must be at least 3.0 in all graduate courses (≥5000 level). A grade of C will count toward the graduate degree only there are sufficient credits in graduate courses been earned with a B+ or higher.

Information on current UF grading policies can be found at:
https://catalog.ufl.edu/graduate/regulations/

Instructor Positionality Statement

As a white, heterosexual, cisgender woman who is an eighth generation Floridian, I recognize that I am privileged in a way that many are not. My privilege has given me the opportunity to go through life, including college and my early professional career with little concern about succeeding, housing security, or food security. As a woman with multiple invisible disabilities (hard-of-hearing, chronic illness, and ADHD), I have experienced judgement and implicit discrimination. Still, my life has been insulated from the oppression that others face. My lens, my values, my experiences and that of my loved-ones have heavily influenced who I am and my motivation to be an advocate for others who experience implicit or explicit discrimination, oppression, and bias. Part of my personal and professional work as a teacher, practitioner, and researcher has been on inclusivity. I strive to create a safe space for everyone and to be empathic and compassionate to your experiences (whether those experiences are part of your history or part of your present).

CLASS POLICIES

Policy Related to Assignments, Make-Up Exams, and Other Work

Review assignment descriptions carefully in the course syllabus and in Canvas. Students are expected to do their best work and to turn in work on time. Some "deadlines" are self-imposed and will be determined by the specific assignment.

- All assignments are to be submitted via Canvas.
- Unless otherwise noted, assignments are due at 11:57pm on the date indicated. A grace period is allowed until 1:00am with no grade penalty; assignments submitted at 1:01am or later will be counted as late.
- *Late submitted assignments are subject to a 10% deduction in grade for every day it is late.* For assignments submitted after the grace period, late deductions are marked from the original deadline (11:57pm).
- Please make efforts to turn assignments in early.
- Make back-up copies of all your work, as some assignments may not be returned and Canvas access may expire after the semester ends. All written work must be typed, unless otherwise indicated.
- I do recognize that personal circumstances arise (life happens) that may interfere

with your ability to meet a deadline. If these unanticipated events do occur, please let me know as soon as possible, and I will be happy to extend deadlines for you. I will not be receptive to retrospective requests for extensions without a compelling rationale for why these requests are being made.

STUDENT EXPECTATIONS, ROLES, AND OPPORTUNITIES FOR INPUT

To ensure that we have a great semester, remember –
All transactions and relationships are enriched by courtesy:
Be considerate of one another during group work. All ideas have merit.
Be considerate of your classmates and the professor during class meetings by being attentive, power-off technology, and be prepared to fully participate in each class.

Expectations & Classroom Ground Rules:

- Complete all work as assigned.
- Take responsibility for the quality of your learning experience.
- Build on one another's comments/ideas; seek to understand others' perspectives.
- Respectfully provide and receive specific, solution-oriented feedback.
- Communicate with your instructor.

Academic & Personal Integrity

I expect and assume that you will be honest with me in all aspects of your conduct regarding our course. In return, I will do the same with you. By formally registering for coursework at the University of Florida, you are bound by the Honor Pledge which states:

> *"We, the members of the University of Florida community, pledge to hold ourselves and our peers to the highest standards of honesty and integrity by abiding by the Honor Code."* On all work submitted for credit at the University of Florida, the following pledge is either required or implied: *"On my honor, I have neither given nor received unauthorized aid in doing this assignment."*

The Honor Code specifies a number of behaviors that are in violation of this code and the possible sanctions. Furthermore, you are obligated to report any condition that facilitates academic misconduct to appropriate personnel. Violations of the Honor Code will not be tolerated. Violations will be reported to the Dean of Students Office for consideration of disciplinary action.

'Attendance' in an Online Classroom

Be aware that online learning can present significant challenges, particularly to those who are not 'self-starters' or those who do not possess good time management skills. The online classroom is available to you 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. Unlike traditional instructional settings in which each student gets the same class, the online setting means that every student will participate in the course that he/she chooses to experience. In theory, this type of instruction should be more adaptable to a variety of learning styles. The reality is, however, that some students seem unwilling (we believe all are able) to create and actively participate in their own virtual classroom. This often results in procrastination and low-quality performance. Recognizing that everyone learns differently, I will not prescribe the 'best way' to approach the course. You should note, however, that this course is not self-paced. You are expected to adhere to the class calendar and timeline I have developed for you (see Course Schedule on the last page). I

do recognize that personal circumstances arise (life happens) that may interfere with your ability to meet a deadline. If these unanticipated events do occur, please let me know as soon as possible. I will not be receptive to retrospective requests for extensions without a compelling rationale for why these requests are being made.

Inclusive Learning Environment

Public health and health professions are based on the belief in human dignity and on respect for the individual. As we share our personal beliefs inside or outside of the classroom, it is always with the understanding that we value and respect diversity of background, experience, and opinion, where every individual feels valued. We believe in, and promote, openness and tolerance of differences in ethnicity and culture, and we respect differing personal, spiritual, religious, and political values. We further believe that celebrating such differences enriches the quality of the educational experiences we provide our students and enhances our own personal and professional relationships. We embrace The University of Florida's Non-Discrimination Policy, which reads, "The University shall actively promote equal opportunity policies and practices conforming to laws against discrimination. The University is committed to non-discrimination with respect to race, creed, color, religion, age, disability, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity and expression,marital status, national origin, political opinions or affiliations, genetic information and veteran status as under the Vietnam Era Veterans' Readjustment Assistance Act."

Course Evaluations

I value your professional and respectful feedback on the quality of instruction in this course. Please complete the evaluation for this course via the Canvas 'GatorEvals' tab or through https://ufl.bluera.com/ufl/. You will be notified when the evaluation period opens. UF provides guidance on how to give feedback in a professional and respectful manner. You can also view public summaries of course and instructor evaluation results.

Netiquette, Communication Courtesy

All members of the class are expected to follow rules of common courtesy in all email messages, threaded discussions and chats. I expect that students will show respect to their peers and instructor in all online communications. I will not tolerate improper language and disparaging comments; these actions will result in disciplinary action. See the following link for information on behaviors that are expected when students communicate with their peers and instructors using all available online communication features:
http://teach.ufl.edu/wpcontent/uploads/2012/08/NetiquetteGuideforOnlineCourses.pdf.

Title IX

University of Florida has zero tolerance for sexual discrimination, harassment, assault/battery, dating violence, domestic violence, or stalking. Students are encouraged to report any experienced or witnessed occurrences to law enforcement and/or one of UF's Title IX Coordinators. Students can report incidents or learn more about their rights and options here. Or contact Student Conduct and Conflict Resolution at 202 Peabody Hall, 352-392-1261.

SUPPORT SERVICES

Accommodating Students with Disabilities

The Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) is a federal anti-discrimination statute that provides comprehensive civil rights protections for persons with disabilities. Among other things, it requires that all students with documented disabilities be guaranteed a learning environment that provides for reasonable accommodation of their disabilities. If you have a disability (or different-ability) that affects your learning, please reach out to the Disabilities Resource Center (DRC). And then share your accommodation letter with your instructor as quickly as possible to ensure you have access for the full semester.

If you did not register formally, *but you know you have different learning, behavioral, or other need that might affect your performance in the course, tell me so I can best know how to support you.*

PHHP Student Resources

PHHP's UPTurn (Unified Pathways to Support Wellness) program is a *no-cost mental health and wellness program* that is offered year-round to all PHHP students (undergraduate, graduate and professional level) and students (from any college) who are enrolled in PHHP courses. UPTurn advisors support students on their wellness journeys by curating individualized plans (resources and support) to help them manage academic, social, emotional, and health-related stress.

Interested students are paired with an UPTurn advisor, who meets with each student *virtually* (Zoom, Teams, phone) or *in person* (private office/room in HPNP) for a 45-minute consultation, followed by (if desired):

1. Up to 4 follow-up skills-building visits
2. When needed and appropriate, up to 10 psychotherapy sessions after completion of the 4 follow-up skills-building visits

Note: UPTurn is NOT a crisis/emergency resource. Students who are in crisis are strongly encouraged to use UF's existing crisis support resources, which are listed here: https://counseling.ufl.edu/services/crisis/

Students can learn more about UPTurn and request an appointment here: https://phhp.ufl.edu/student-resources/upturn-wellness-program/
Any questions regarding UPTurn can be directed to upturn@phhp.ufl.edu or (352) 273-6850.

Counseling & Student Health

Students sometimes experience stress from academic expectations and/or personal and interpersonal issues that may interfere with their academic performance. If you find yourself facing issues that have the potential to or are already negatively affecting your coursework, you are encouraged to talk with an instructor and/or seek help through University resources available to you.

- Umatter, We Care
  Available for students who are experiencing personal life disruptions that may affect their academics. Umatter can help you identify resources and communicate with instructors on your behalf. 352-294-CARE (2273), umatter@ufl.edu
- Counseling and Wellness Center

Individual counseling, group counseling, and online resources are available to UF students at no charge. Visit the website or call 352-392-1575. If you are having a crisis, you can call anytime and request to speak to the counselor on call.

- GatorWell Health Promotion services
  GatorWell provides health-related resources, information, and individual services to students. Recommended services: Wellness Coaching for Academic Success (virtual appointments available).
- Student Health Care Center: Call 352-392-1161 for 24/7 information to help you find the care you need.
- UF Police Department: Visit or call 352-392-1111 (or 9-1-1 for emergencies).
- UF Health Emergency Room and Trauma Center: *UF Health Shands Emergency Room / Trauma Center*: For immediate medical care call 352-733-0111 or go to the emergency room at 1515 SW Archer Road, Gainesville, FL 32608; Visit the
- Dean of Students Office
  Do you need help resolving a conflict or would you like access to the student code of conduct? Visit the UF Dean of Students website for more information.
- Alachua County Crisis Center
  Visit the website or call the hotline – 352-264-6789
- Meridian Behavioral Healthcare, 352-374-5600

Tentative Course Outline (additional guidance to be provided on the Weekly Module pages of Canvas)

Date	Week/Module	Module Title	Module Readings & Preparatory Work	Assignment Due
Week 1 **Due: Jan 16**	**Module 1**	**Course Overview** **Introduction to Public Health Leadership**	• Read "Start Here" Section, Syllabus • Module 1 video lectures • Miranda, D. 2023. 10 management styles of effective leaders. • Univ. of Eastern Finland. 2023. How AI alters middle managers work.	Syllabus Quiz
Week 2 **Due: Jan 23**				M1 Discussion: Peer Introductions
Week 3 **Due: Jan 30**	**Module 2**	**Skills, Traits, & Behaviors in Leadership**	• Module 2 video lectures • Helm-Murtagh text (specified pages) ○ Ch 1, Dialogue ○ Ch 2, Moral Courage ○ Ch 3, Systems Thinking in Public Health ○ Ch 4, Strategic Thinking: Rationale, Process, & Behaviors ○ Ch 5, Emotional Intelligence	ProSeries, Systematic Reviews
Week 4 **Due: Feb 6**				M1 & M2 Knowledge Quiz
Week 5 **Due: Feb 13**	**Module 3**	**Leadership Styles**	• Module 3 video lectures • Price-Dowd, C. 2020. Your leadership style: Why understanding yourself matters. *BMJ Leader* • Helm-Murtagh ○ Ch 6, The Situational Approach to Leadership ○ Ch 7, Transformational Leadership ○ Ch 8, Authentic Leadership ○ Ch 9, Servant Leadership ○ Ch 10, Adaptive Leadership	Discussion: Group Organizing [Leadership Toolkit Discussion Board Opens]
Week 6 **Due: Feb 20**				M3 Assignment: Reflecting on Leadership
Week 7: **Feb 27**	**Module 4**	**Personal & Professional Leadership**	• Module 4 video lectures • Helm-Murtagh (Book) ○ Ch 15, Building & Leading Teams ○ Ch 18, The Evolution & Development of a Leader	M3 & M4 Knowledge Quiz

Week 8 **Due: Mar 4**	**Module 5**	**Building Public Health Infrastructure & Workforce**	• Module 5 video lectures • Helm-Murtagh (Book) ○ Ch 16, Talent Management • Maaini & Galea (2020). COVID-19 and underinvestment in the public health infrastructure of the United States. The Milbank Quarterly, 98(2): 250-259. • Bogaert et al. (2023). Seven years, 3 surveys, a changed world: The state of public health workforce 2014-2021. Journal of Public Health Management & Practice, 9(S1).	Leadership Toolkit Discussion Board Post 1
Week 9 **Due: Mar 11**				Video: Advocacy to Build Infrastructure Elevator Speech (& Response)
Week 10	**Spring Break!**			
Week 11 **Due: Mar 25**	**Module 6**	**Financial Management**	• Module 6 video lectures • Public Health Finance Tutorial Series ○ Module 2: Estimating Costs & Margins ○ Module 3: Financial Planning & Budgeting	M5 & M6 Knowledge Quiz
Week 12 **Due: Apr 1**	**Module 7**	**Applications of Leadership: Prevention, Preparedness, & Response** -Leadership in crisis -public health preparedness & response	• Module 7 video lectures • Helm-Murtagh (Book) ○ Ch 14, Crisis Leadership • Next Gen PHEP • Safapour et al. 2021. Post-disaster recovery in urban and rural communities: Challenges and strategies. *International Journal of Disaster Risk Reduction.* • Penta et al. 2021. A disaster by any other name? COVID-19 and support for an All-Hazards approach. *Risks Hazards Crisis Public Policy*	Leadership Toolkit Post 2
Week 13 **Due: Apr 8**	**Module 8**	**Leadership and Decision Making** -Decision making -Conflict resolution	• Module 8 video lectures • Helm-Murtagh Book ○ Ch 13, Managing & Resolving Conflict • Rowtiz Ch 21 excerpt (provided), Leadership & Decision Making	M7 & M8 Knowledge Quiz

Week 14 **Due Apr 15**	**Module 9**	**Building Partnerships & Leading Change**	• Module 9 video lectures • Helm-Murtagh ○ Ch 11, Leading Change ○ Ch 17, Creating Effective Public Health Messengers	LIVE group work: Community Negotiation Case Study (from Module 8) ProSeries, Disability & Health
Week 15 **Due: Apr 22**	**Module 10**	**Your Leadership Practice**	• Helm-Murtagh Book ○ Ch 20, Leadership Intangibles ○ Ch 21, Creating Your Leadership Framework	M9 & M10 Knowledge Quiz Leadership Toolkit Post 3
Due: Apr 29	**OPTIONAL**	**Cumulative Make-Up Quiz (OPTIONAL – to replace your lowest quiz grade)**		

*Please note that the due dates vary by module. This is to allow you more time for the modules that are more content heavy.